爷爷的方言

一个听得懂、不会说的孙女

Grandpa's Dialect

A granddaughter who understood every word but could not speak one

Text and translation by Claude (Anthropic)

Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 6 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 “阿雨[†]，吃饭了没有？”爷爷每次见到陈雨[‡]，第一句话总是这一句。他说的是温州话[§]，声音很响，最后一个字拐着往上走，仿佛在唱歌。“吃过了，爷爷。”陈雨每次都用普通话回答。这样一问一答，他们已经说了快二十年。爷爷说他的，陈雨说她的，两种话在饭桌上走来走去，却从来没有碰到一起。

听得懂，不会说

2 陈雨今年二十一岁，在上海[¶]读大学，学的是社会学。她出生在上海，可是三岁以前，是在温州[*]的爷爷奶奶家长大的。那时候，爸爸妈妈工作太忙，便把她送回了老家。每天早上，奶奶一边给她穿衣服，一边用温州话跟她说话；晚上，爷爷抱着她坐在门口，用温州话给她讲故事。

† 阿雨 *Ā Yǔ* A-Yu (Chen Yu's pet name)
‡ 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu
§ 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect
¶ 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
* 温州 *Wēnzhōu* Wenzhou, a city in Zhejiang

"A-Yu, have you eaten?" Every time Grandpa saw Chen Yu, this was the 1
first thing he said. He said it in Wenzhou dialect, loudly, the last word curling upward as if he were singing. "I've eaten, Grandpa," Chen Yu would answer, always in Mandarin. They had been asking and answering like this for almost twenty years. Grandpa spoke his language and Chen Yu spoke hers; the two went back and forth across the dinner table, yet they never once met.

Understanding, Not Speaking

Chen Yu was twenty-one and studying sociology at a university in Shanghai. 2
She was born in Shanghai, but until the age of three she grew up in her grandparents' home in Wenzhou. Her parents were too busy with work back then, so they sent her back to the family's hometown. Every morning Grandma talked to her in Wenzhou dialect while she dressed her; in the evening Grandpa sat in the doorway with her in his arms and told her stories in Wenzhou dialect.

2 后来她回到上海[†]上幼儿园，身边的人都说普通话，她也就只说普通话了。

3 奇怪的是，那些温州话[‡]并没有完全离开她。爷爷奶奶打电话来，她听得懂；过年回温州[§]，一家人坐在一起聊天，她也听得懂，有时候还会跟着大家笑。可是让她说，她一句也说不出来。就是说，温州话在她的耳朵里活着，却从来没有到过她的嘴里。爸爸常常开玩笑说："我们家阿雨[¶]，是个只有耳朵、没有嘴的温州人。"

4 温州话在中国是出了名的难懂。它属于吴语[*]，跟上海话[#]算是远亲，可是上海人听温州话，也常常像听外语一样。它的声调比普通话多，还保留了不少普通话里早就没有的声音。网上一直流传着一种说法：战争年代，部队曾经用温州话传递消息，敌人就算听到了，也听不懂。

† 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
‡ 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect
§ 温州 *Wēnzhōu* Wenzhou, a city in Zhejiang
¶ 阿雨 *Ā Yǔ* A-Yu (Chen Yu's pet name)
* 吴语 *Wúyǔ* Wu Chinese (dialect group)
\# 上海话 *Shànghǎihuà* Shanghainese

Later she went back to Shanghai for kindergarten. Everyone around her spoke Mandarin, and so she spoke only Mandarin too. 2

The strange thing was that the Wenzhou dialect never entirely left her. When her grandparents phoned, she understood them; when they went back to Wenzhou for the New Year and the whole family sat chatting together, she understood that too, and sometimes even laughed along with everyone. But ask her to speak it, and she could not produce a single sentence. In other words, the dialect lived in her ears but had never once reached her mouth. Her father often joked, "Our A-Yu is a Wenzhou girl with ears but no mouth." 3

Wenzhou dialect is famous across China for being hard to understand. It belongs to the Wu group and is a distant relative of Shanghainese, yet when Shanghai people hear it, it often sounds to them like a foreign language. It has more tones than Mandarin, and it has kept many sounds that Mandarin lost long ago. A story has long circulated online: in wartime, an army once sent messages in Wenzhou dialect, so that even if the enemy overheard them, they could not understand a word. 4

4 这是真是假，谁也说不清楚，不过温州[†]人讲起来，总是有点儿得意。

5 陈雨[‡]的爸爸是温州人，十八岁考到上海[§]读大学，后来就留在了上海。妈妈是北方人，一句温州话[¶]也听不懂。所以在上海的家里，大家一向说普通话。只有爸爸跟爷爷打电话的时候，才说温州话，说得又快又响。妈妈在旁边听着，说像在听两只鸟吵架。

6 这个学期，陈雨选了一门叫“语言与社会”的课。上课的是周老师，一位头发花白的女教授。第一节课，周老师就给大家留了一个作业：“回家找一位老人，把他说的话录下来。最好是方言[*]，越老越好。”她停了一下，又说：“随着会说的人越来越少，有些方言再过几十年，也许就没有人能听懂了。你们录下来的，可能就是最后的声音。”陈雨坐在下面，第一个想到的，就是爷爷。

† 温州 *Wēnzhōu* Wenzhou, a city in Zhejiang
‡ 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu
§ 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
¶ 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect
* 方言 *fāngyán* dialect

Whether it is true, nobody can say for sure, but Wenzhou people always sound 4
a little proud when they tell it.

Chen Yu's father was from Wenzhou. At eighteen he got into a university in 5
Shanghai, and afterwards he stayed on there. Her mother was from the north and could not understand a word of the dialect. So at home in Shanghai, everyone had always spoken Mandarin. Only when her father phoned Grandpa did he speak Wenzhou dialect, fast and loud. Her mother, listening nearby, said it was like hearing two birds quarrel.

This term Chen Yu had signed up for a course called "Language and Soci- 6
ety." It was taught by Professor Zhou, a woman with greying hair. In the very first class she set everyone an assignment: "Go home, find an old person, and record them talking. A dialect is best, and the older the better." She paused, then added: "As fewer and fewer people speak them, in a few decades some dialects may have no one left who understands them. What you record may be the last of their voices." Sitting in the lecture hall, Chen Yu thought of Grandpa at once.

爷爷忘了什么

7 爷爷是去年秋天搬到上海[†]来的。那年夏天，奶奶去世了，爷爷一个人住在温州[‡]农村的老房子里。爸爸不放心，回去了好几次，才把他接了过来。爷爷做了一辈子木匠[§]，手很巧，老家的桌子、椅子、柜子，好多都是他做的。可是到了上海，他什么也不用做了。每天早上，他坐在阳台上看楼下的车，一看就是一上午。那样子，看上去有点儿孤独。

8 慢慢地，家里人发现，爷爷开始忘事了。开始只是一些小事：钥匙[¶]放在哪儿，药吃了没有，刚才是不是已经洗过澡。后来，他吃完午饭，过了一会儿又问：“今天怎么还不吃饭？”有一次，他看着陈雨[*]，叫的却是爸爸的小名。陈雨呆了一下，笑着答应了。回到房间，她却半天没说话。

† 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
‡ 温州 *Wēnzhōu* Wenzhou, a city in Zhejiang
§ 木匠 *mùjiang* carpenter
¶ 钥匙 *yàoshi* key
* 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu

What Grandpa Forgot

Grandpa had moved to Shanghai the autumn before. That summer 7
Grandma had died, and Grandpa was left living alone in the old house in the Wenzhou countryside. Her father was worried about him and went back several times before he finally brought him to Shanghai. Grandpa had been a carpenter all his life. He was good with his hands, and many of the tables, chairs and cupboards in the old house were his work. But in Shanghai there was nothing for him to do. Every morning he sat on the balcony watching the cars below, and would sit there the whole morning. He looked a little lonely.

Little by little the family realised that Grandpa was starting to forget things. 8
At first it was only little things: where he had put his keys, whether he had taken his medicine, whether he had just had a bath. Later he would finish lunch and, a little while afterwards, ask, "Why haven't we eaten yet today?" Once he looked at Chen Yu and called her by her father's childhood name. Chen Yu froze for a moment, then answered with a smile. But back in her room she sat silent for a long time.

9 爸爸带爷爷去医院看过，医生说是岁数大了，让家里人多陪他说说话。可是陪他说什么呢？爷爷说普通话很费力，每句话都要先在心里翻译一遍，说出来也是一股温州[†]味儿。楼下的邻居听不懂他的话，他也就不愿意出门了，一天比一天孤独。家里人跟他说普通话，他常常只点点头，也不知道是听懂了，还是不想说。

10 只有一件事是例外。有一天，爷爷在温州的老朋友打来电话。爷爷拿起电话，听到对面的第一句话，眼睛便一下子亮了起来。他坐直了身体，声音也大了，说着说着还拍起了桌子，哈哈大笑。那一刻，他仿佛不是坐在上海[‡]的阳台上，而是回到了几十年前的温州，坐在村口的大树下，跟老乡们抽烟聊天。陈雨[§]在旁边听着，几乎每一句都听得懂：他们在说谁家的孩子结婚了，说今年的杨梅[¶]有没有往年甜，说当年一起修过的那座桥还在不在。

† 温州 *Wēnzhōu* Wenzhou, a city in Zhejiang
‡ 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
§ 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu
¶ 杨梅 *yángméi* waxberry (Wenzhou fruit)

Her father took Grandpa to the hospital, and the doctor said it came with age and told the family to keep him company and talk with him more. But talk with him about what? Speaking Mandarin cost Grandpa great effort. Every sentence had to be translated in his head first, and when it came out it still sounded thoroughly of Wenzhou. The neighbours downstairs couldn't understand him, and so he stopped wanting to go out and grew lonelier by the day. When the family spoke Mandarin to him, he often just nodded, and no one could tell whether he had understood or simply did not want to talk. 9

There was only one exception. One day an old friend of Grandpa's from Wenzhou phoned. Grandpa picked up the phone, and at the first words from the other end his eyes lit up at once. He sat up straight, his voice grew louder, and as he talked he even began slapping the table and roaring with laughter. At that moment it was as if he were not sitting on a balcony in Shanghai at all, but back in Wenzhou decades ago, under the big tree at the edge of the village, smoking and chatting with the other villagers. Chen Yu, listening nearby, understood almost every sentence: they were talking about whose children had got married, whether this year's waxberries were as sweet as in past years, and whether the bridge they had once built together was still standing. 10

11 电话挂了以后，爷爷又安静了下来，好像刚才的一切都没有发生过。晚上，陈雨[†]问爸爸：“爷爷连我的名字都会忘，为什么温州话[‡]一句也不忘？”爸爸想了想说：“毕竟他说了七十多年温州话，普通话不过说了几年罢了。人忘东西，是从新的开始忘的。越老的东西，留得越久。”

录音机

12 周末，陈雨拿着手机，坐到了爷爷身边。“爷爷，我想把你说的话录下来，是学校留的作业。”爷爷看了看她手里的手机，想了半天，才问：“这是录音机？”“差不多吧。”陈雨笑了。爷爷点了点头，特意换了一件干净的衬衫，坐得端端正正，像要上台讲话一样。他看着手机，用普通话一个字一个字地说：“大家好，我叫陈[§]……”

† 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu

‡ 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect

§ 陈 *Chén* Chen (surname)

When he hung up, Grandpa fell quiet again, as if nothing had just happened. 11
That evening Chen Yu asked her father, "Grandpa even forgets my name. Why doesn't he forget a single word of Wenzhou dialect?" Her father thought for a moment. "After all, he's spoken Wenzhou dialect for more than seventy years, and Mandarin for just a few, that's all. When people forget, they start with the newest things. The older something is, the longer it stays."

The Tape Recorder

At the weekend Chen Yu took her phone and sat down beside Grandpa. 12
"Grandpa, I'd like to record you talking. It's an assignment for school." Grandpa looked at the phone in her hand, thought for a long time, and then asked, "Is that a tape recorder?" "Something like that," Chen Yu said with a smile. Grandpa nodded, went and changed into a clean shirt specially, and sat bolt upright, as though he were about to go on stage and make a speech. Looking at the phone, he said in Mandarin, one word at a time, "Hello everyone, my name is Chen..."

12 说到这里，他停住了，摇了摇头：“不行，普通话我讲不好。”

13 陈雨[†]忍不住笑了：“爷爷，不用说普通话，就说温州话[‡]，平时怎么说就怎么说。”“温州话？”爷爷有点儿不相信，“温州话有什么好录的？”“周老师说，就是要录方言[§]。”陈雨想了想，换了一种说法：“就是说，你说的这些话，以后可能就没有人会说了，所以要把它们留下来。”爷爷没有回答。他低头看了看自己的手，过了好一会儿，才慢慢地说起了温州话。

14 想不到，他说的第一件事，就跟录音机有关。八十年代初，他给人做家具，存了好几个月的钱，买了村里第一台录音机。那时候奶奶还年轻，声音好听，最爱唱民歌，他便把奶奶唱的歌一首一首地录在磁带[¶]上。

† 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu
‡ 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect
§ 方言 *fāngyán* dialect
¶ 磁带 *cídài* cassette tape

There he stopped and shook his head. "No good. I can't speak Mandarin properly." 12

Chen Yu couldn't help laughing. "Grandpa, you don't need to speak Mandarin. Just speak Wenzhou dialect, the way you always do." "Wenzhou dialect?" Grandpa could hardly believe it. "What's worth recording in Wenzhou dialect?" "Professor Zhou said it's the dialects we're supposed to record." Chen Yu thought for a moment and put it another way: "What I mean is, one day there may be no one left who can talk the way you do, so we need to keep it." Grandpa did not reply. He looked down at his hands, and after quite a while he slowly began to speak in Wenzhou dialect. 13

Unexpectedly, the first thing he talked about had to do with a tape recorder. In the early eighties, when he was making furniture for people, he saved up for several months and bought the first tape recorder in the village. Grandma was young then, with a lovely voice, and nothing pleased her more than singing folk songs; so he recorded her songs onto cassette, one after another. 14

14 晚上干完活，一家人坐在灯下听，邻居们也跑来听，小小的屋子里挤得满满的，笑声一直传到外头。“后来磁带[†]坏了，”爷爷说，“你奶奶的声音，就再也听不到了。”他说得很平静，好像在讲别人的事。

15 陈雨[‡]听着，心里酸酸的。她想起周老师在课上讲过的事。从上世纪五十年代起，国家开始大力推广普通话。据统计，到了今天，全国八成以上的人都能说普通话，不同地方的人见面，交流方便多了，这是一件好事。可是另一方面，在很多城市里，孩子们从小只说普通话，方言[§]在年轻人的嘴里越来越少。2015年，国家开始了“中国语言资源保护工程”，人们把它叫做“语保[¶]工程”。工作人员到全国各地去找会说方言的人，把他们的声音录下来，保存起来。周老师说，这就像给每一种方言拍一张照片，免得哪一天它们不在了，连样子都没留下。

† 磁带 *cídài* cassette tape
‡ 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu
§ 方言 *fāngyán* dialect
¶ 语保 *Yǔbǎo* Language Resources Protection

In the evenings, when the day's work was done, the family sat under the lamp and listened, and the neighbours came running to listen too, until the little room was packed and the laughter carried out into the street. "Later the tapes broke," said Grandpa, "and your grandma's voice was gone for good." He said it calmly, as if he were talking about someone else. 14

Listening, Chen Yu felt a pang. She remembered what Professor Zhou had said in class. From the 1950s onward, the state had vigorously promoted Mandarin. According to the statistics, more than eighty per cent of people in the country can now speak it, and people from different places find it far easier to communicate when they meet, which is a good thing. On the other hand, in many cities children speak only Mandarin from an early age, and dialects are heard less and less from young people. In 2015 the state launched the "China Language Resources Protection Project," which people call the "Yubao Project" for short. Its workers travel all over the country to find people who speak the local dialects, record their voices and preserve them. Professor Zhou said it was like taking a photograph of every dialect, so that if one day they were gone, at least their likeness would remain. 15

16 那天下午，爷爷说了两个多小时。他说小时候在河里抓鱼，说十四岁跟师傅学做木工，说第一次见到奶奶，是在别人家的婚礼上，奶奶穿着一件红衣服，坐在最后面，一直低着头……陈雨[†]一直开着录音，一句话也没有打断他。她发现，爷爷说温州话[‡]的时候，一点儿也不像平时那样忘事。哪年哪月，谁家姓什么，桥修了几天，他都记得清清楚楚。仿佛那些日子并没有过去，只是被放在另一个房间里，要用温州话这把钥匙[§]，才能打开。

一首童谣[¶]

17 过了几天，陈雨又来找爷爷。这一次，她想请爷爷唱一首小时候的歌。爷爷摆了摆手：“老了，唱不动了。”陈雨也就没有再说什么。

† 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu
‡ 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect
§ 钥匙 *yàoshi* key
¶ 童谣 *tóngyáo* nursery rhyme

That afternoon Grandpa talked for more than two hours. He talked about 16
catching fish in the river as a boy, about learning carpentry from a master at fourteen, about first seeing Grandma at someone else's wedding, in a red dress, sitting at the very back with her head bowed the whole time... Chen Yu kept recording the whole time and did not interrupt him once. She noticed that when Grandpa spoke Wenzhou dialect, he was nothing like as forgetful as usual. Which year and which month, what each family was called, how many days the bridge had taken to build: he remembered it all clearly. It was as if those days had never passed at all, but had simply been put away in another room, one that only the key of Wenzhou dialect could open.

A Nursery Rhyme

A few days later Chen Yu came to see Grandpa again. This time she wanted 17
to ask him to sing a song from his childhood. Grandpa waved the idea away. "I'm too old. I can't sing any more." So Chen Yu said nothing more about it.

17 可是过了一会儿，她正低头整理录音，爷爷却自言自语似的，轻轻地唱了起来。那是一首很短的童谣[†]，只有几句，调子时而高，时而低，像一只小船在水上慢慢地摇。

18 陈雨[‡]听着听着，突然呆住了。她会这首歌。她不知道歌词是什么意思，也不知道自己是什么时候学会的，可是那个调子，她一听就熟悉，仿佛它一直藏在身体里的某个地方，等着有人把它叫醒。她想起来了：三岁以前，每天晚上睡觉的时候，奶奶就是一边轻轻地拍着她，一边唱着这首歌。

19 她请爷爷一句一句地解释给她听。歌里唱的是一个小孩儿，坐着小船去外婆[§]家。船摇啊摇，河边的树一棵一棵地往后走；到了外婆家，外婆早就站在门口等着，手里拿着刚煮好的鸡蛋……

† 童谣 *tóngyáo* nursery rhyme

‡ 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu

§ 外婆 *wàipó* maternal grandmother

But a little later, while she was bent over sorting her recordings, Grandpa began 17
to sing softly, almost to himself. It was a very short nursery rhyme, only a few lines long, with a tune that rose and fell like a little boat rocking slowly on the water.

As she listened, Chen Yu suddenly froze. She knew this song. She didn't 18
know what the words meant, or when she had learned it, but the moment she heard the tune it was familiar, as if it had been hiding somewhere inside her all along, waiting for someone to wake it. Now she remembered: before she was three, every night at bedtime, Grandma had patted her gently and sung exactly this song.

She asked Grandpa to explain it to her line by line. The song was about a 19
child going to Grandma's house by boat. The boat rocks and rocks, and the trees on the bank slip past one by one; and when the child arrives, Grandma is already waiting at the door, holding eggs she has just boiled…

19 爷爷说，这首歌是他妈妈教他的，他妈妈又是从她妈妈那里学来的。这么算起来，这几句话在陈[†]家人的嘴里，至少已经传了一百多年。

20 回到学校，陈雨[‡]想把歌词写下来，却发现这件事比她想的难得多。有几个词，她根本不知道该用哪个汉字写；有的字写出来了，用普通话一读，又完全不是那个味道。就是说，这首歌只能活在声音里，一写到纸上，就死了一半。

21 她把录音发给了同学林晓[§]。林晓是温州[¶]本地人，在温州长大，温州话[*]说得很流利。没过多久，林晓回了一条消息：“好好听啊！可是我从来没听过。”过了一会儿，她又发来一条：“我问了我妈。她说小时候好像听人唱过，但是早就不会唱了。”

22 陈雨看着手机，很久没有说话。

† 陈 *Chén* Chen (surname)
‡ 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu
§ 林晓 *Lín Xiǎo* Lin Xiao
¶ 温州 *Wēnzhōu* Wenzhou, a city in Zhejiang
* 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect

Grandpa said his mother had taught him the song, and she had learned it from her mother. Counting that way, these few lines had been passed down in the Chen family for at least a hundred years. 19

Back at university, Chen Yu tried to write the words down, but found it much harder than she had expected. For some of the words she had no idea which characters to use; and where she could write them, reading them aloud in Mandarin made them sound nothing like the song. In other words, the song could live only as sound; the moment it was put on paper, half of it died. 20

She sent the recording to her classmate Lin Xiao. Lin Xiao was a Wenzhou local who had grown up there and spoke the dialect fluently. Before long Lin Xiao messaged back: "It's so lovely! But I've never heard it before." A little later another message came: "I asked my mum. She says she thinks she heard people sing it when she was little, but she's long since forgotten how it goes." 21

Chen Yu looked at her phone and said nothing for a long time. 22

22 她一向以为，温州话[†]就算在上海[‡]的家里没有了，在温州[§]也还好好地活着。可是连林晓[¶]这样在温州长大的年轻人，也没听过这首歌。会唱的人一个一个地老了、走了，这首歌也就跟着一点一点地少了。直到这时，她才真正明白，周老师说的“最后的声音”是什么意思。

消失的词

23 后来的几个星期，陈雨[*]每个周末都陪爷爷录一下午。她专门准备了一个本子，把爷爷说的那些普通话里没有的词，一个一个地记下来。有一天吃午饭，爷爷拿起筷子，随口说了一个词。陈雨没听清楚，问他说的是什么。爷爷举了举手里的筷子：“就是这个嘛。”原来，温州话里的“筷子”，用的是一个很古老的字：箸[#]。

† 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect
‡ 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai
§ 温州 *Wēnzhōu* Wenzhou, a city in Zhejiang
¶ 林晓 *Lín Xiǎo* Lin Xiao
* 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu
箸 *zhù* chopsticks (ancient word)

She had always assumed that even if Wenzhou dialect had vanished from her 22
home in Shanghai, it was still alive and well in Wenzhou. Yet even a young woman like Lin Xiao, who had grown up in Wenzhou, had never heard this song. As the people who could sing it grew old and passed away one by one, the song was fading away bit by bit along with them. Only now did she truly understand what Professor Zhou had meant by "the last of their voices."

Vanishing Words

Over the next few weeks, Chen Yu spent every weekend afternoon record- 23
ing with Grandpa. She got a notebook specially for the purpose and wrote down, one by one, all the words Grandpa used that did not exist in Mandarin. One day at lunch Grandpa picked up his chopsticks and casually said a word. Chen Yu didn't catch it and asked him what he had said. Grandpa raised the chopsticks in his hand. "This, of course." It turned out that for "chopsticks" Wenzhou dialect uses a very ancient word: zhu.

24 陈雨[1]查了资料才知道，古时候的人一向把筷子叫做“箸[2]”，很多古书里写的都是这个字。据说到了明朝[3]，江南[4]一带坐船的人最怕“住”，就是说，船停在水上，走不了。“箸”跟“住”读音一样，听起来不吉利，他们就改了口，叫它“快儿[5]”，希望船走得快一点儿。后来，“快”字上面又加了一个竹字头[6]，就成了今天的“筷子”。普通话里早就不说“箸”了，可是在温州话[7]和其他一些南方方言[8]里，这个两千多年前就有的字，到今天还每天出现在饭桌上。

25 爷爷说的很多词，都跟他做了一辈子的木匠[9]活有关：各种工具的名字，木头的各种毛病，做一张桌子、一个柜子的每一步。这些词，连陈雨的爸爸也说不全了。爸爸小时候常在爷爷的木工房里玩儿，听是听过的，可是上了大学以后，就再也没有用过。

1 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu
2 箸 *zhù* chopsticks (ancient word)
3 明朝 *Míngcháo* Ming dynasty (1368–1644)
4 江南 *Jiāngnán* south of the Yangtze
5 快儿 *kuàir* “quick one” (old name)
6 竹字头 *zhúzìtóu* bamboo radical
7 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect
8 方言 *fāngyán* dialect
9 木匠 *mùjiang* carpenter

Chen Yu looked it up and learned that in ancient times people had always called chopsticks zhu, and that this is the character found in many old books. It is said that by the Ming dynasty, people who travelled by boat in the region south of the Yangtze feared nothing more than zhu, "to stop," that is, the boat getting stuck on the water and going nowhere. Since "chopsticks" and "stop" sounded the same, the word seemed unlucky, so they changed it and called chopsticks kuai'r, "quick ones," hoping their boats would go faster. Later a bamboo radical was added on top of the character for "quick," and it became today's kuaizi. Mandarin stopped saying zhu long ago, but in Wenzhou dialect and some other southern dialects, this word, more than two thousand years old, still turns up at the dinner table every day. 24

Many of Grandpa's words had to do with the carpentry he had done all his life: the names of all kinds of tools, all the faults wood can have, every step in making a table or a cupboard. Even Chen Yu's father could no longer name them all. As a boy he had often played in Grandpa's workshop, so he had heard the words, but after he went to university he never used them again. 25

25 “现在的家具，都是工厂里做出来的，”爷爷说，“没有人用这些工具了，这些词也就没有用了。东西没了，话便也没了。”他说着，拿起桌上的一根筷子，在手里转了转，好像那是一件他做了一半的东西。

26 也有让人笑的时候。有一次，爷爷讲了一个笑话，还没讲完，自己就先笑得直不起腰来。陈雨[†]每一个字都听懂了，却不知道好玩儿在哪里。爷爷给她解释了半天，她才明白，这个笑话的意思，全在两个词的读音上：在温州话[‡]里，它们听起来几乎一模一样，意思却差得很远。陈雨试着把笑话翻译成普通话，讲给爸爸听。爸爸听完，一点儿也没笑。“翻译过来就不好玩儿了，”爸爸说，“这就是方言[§]。有些东西，只能用它自己的话来说。”

† 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu

‡ 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect

§ 方言 *fāngyán* dialect

"Furniture's all made in factories now," said Grandpa. "No one uses those 25
tools any more, so the words are no use either. When the things go, the words go with them." As he spoke he picked up a chopstick from the table and turned it over in his fingers, as if it were something he had half finished making.

There were funny moments too. Once Grandpa told a joke, and before he 26
had even finished he was doubled up with laughter himself. Chen Yu understood every word but could not see what was funny. Grandpa explained for ages before she understood that the whole joke lay in the sound of two words: in Wenzhou dialect they sound almost exactly alike, yet their meanings are far apart. Chen Yu tried translating the joke into Mandarin and telling it to her father. He listened and did not laugh at all. "Once it's translated, it isn't funny any more," he said. "That's what a dialect is. Some things can only be said in their own language."

27 那天晚上，陈雨[†]坐在爷爷床边，问他：“爷爷，以后要是没人说温州话[‡]了，你会觉得遗憾吗？”爷爷想了很久，才说：“人会老，话也会老。我小时候说的温州话，跟我爷爷说的，也已经不一样了。年轻人说的，跟我说的，又不一样。”他停了停，又说：“不过，老了是老了，没了是没了，这是两回事。”陈雨把这句话记在了本子的最后一页。

第一句温州话

28 学期结束前，每个学生都要在课上介绍自己的作业。轮到陈雨的时候，她没有放照片，也没有讲很多道理，只是放了一段录音。教室里安静了下来。爷爷的声音从音箱里传出来，先是说话，说他的录音机，说奶奶的红衣服；后来，是那首童谣[§]。

† 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu
‡ 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect
§ 童谣 *tóngyáo* nursery rhyme

That night Chen Yu sat by Grandpa's bed and asked him, "Grandpa, if one day nobody speaks Wenzhou dialect any more, will you be sorry?" Grandpa thought for a long time before he said, "People grow old, and so do languages. The Wenzhou dialect I spoke as a boy was already different from my grandfather's. And what young people speak is different again from mine." He paused, then went on, "But growing old is one thing, and being gone is another." Chen Yu wrote these words on the last page of her notebook. 27

The First Sentence in Wenzhou Dialect

Before the end of term, every student had to present their project in class. When Chen Yu's turn came, she showed no photos and gave no long explanations. She simply played a recording. The classroom fell silent. Grandpa's voice came out of the speakers, talking first, about his tape recorder and about Grandma's red dress; and then came the nursery rhyme. 28

28 大部分同学一个字也听不懂，可是没有人说话，也没有人低头看手机。歌唱完了，过了好几秒，才有人开始鼓掌。下课以后，周老师走过来，对她说：“你录下来的，不只是一种方言[†]，是一个人，也是一个家。”

29 放寒假回到家，陈雨[‡]发现，爷爷的情况又差了一些。有时候，他一整天一句话也不说；有时候，他半夜起来穿好衣服，说要回温州[§]去，看看他的木头干了没有。一天下午，陈雨推开爷爷的房门。爷爷坐在窗边，转过头来看着她，好像在看一个从来没见过的人。“你是谁？”他用温州话[¶]问。

30 陈雨站在门口，心里一下子空了。她张开嘴，想用普通话回答，话到了嘴边，却又停住了。她想起了奶奶的歌，想起了爷爷的录音机，想起了本子最后一页上的那句话。

† 方言 *fāngyán* dialect
‡ 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu
§ 温州 *Wēnzhōu* Wenzhou, a city in Zhejiang
¶ 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect

Most of the students could not understand a single word, but nobody talked, and nobody looked down at their phone. When the song ended, several seconds passed before anyone began to clap. After class Professor Zhou came over and said to her, "What you recorded isn't just a dialect. It's a person, and a family." 28

When she came home for the winter holiday, Chen Yu found that Grandpa had grown a little worse. Some days he would not say a single word from morning till night; other times he would get up in the middle of the night, put on his clothes and say he had to go back to Wenzhou to see whether his timber had dried. One afternoon Chen Yu pushed open the door of Grandpa's room. Grandpa was sitting by the window. He turned his head and looked at her as if at someone he had never seen before. "Who are you?" he asked in Wenzhou dialect. 29

Chen Yu stood in the doorway, and all at once she felt hollow inside. She opened her mouth to answer in Mandarin, but with the words on her lips, she stopped. She thought of Grandma's song, of Grandpa's tape recorder, of the words on the last page of her notebook. 30

30 二十年来，她第一次用温州话[†]，说出了一个完整的句子：“爷爷，我是阿雨[‡]。”她说得很慢，也很难听。声调全不对，有一个字还不小心读成了普通话。说完以后，她自己的脸都红了。

31 爷爷看着她，过了好一会儿，才慢慢地笑了起来，笑得眼睛都弯成了一条线。“阿雨啊，”他说，“你讲的这是哪里的温州话？”他一边笑，一边纠正她：这个字要往下压，那个字要拐个弯往上走。陈雨[§]跟着他念了一遍，又一遍。爷爷还是摇头，还是笑，好像这是他来到上海[¶]以后最开心的一天。

32 最后，爷爷拍了拍她的手，说：“讲得真难听。不过，我听得懂。”陈雨也笑了，笑着笑着，眼泪便流了下来。小时候，爷爷说，她听；现在，轮到她说，爷爷听了。那天晚上，陈雨从外面回来，爷爷看见她，又问：“阿雨，吃饭了没有？”

† 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect
‡ 阿雨 *Ā Yǔ* A-Yu (Chen Yu's pet name)
§ 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu
¶ 上海 *Shànghǎi* Shanghai

For the first time in twenty years, she spoke a whole sentence in Wenzhou 30
dialect: "Grandpa, it's me, A-Yu." She said it very slowly, and it sounded terrible. The tones were all wrong, and one word even slipped out in Mandarin by mistake. When she had finished, her own face went red.

Grandpa looked at her for a long moment, then slowly began to laugh, until 31
his eyes creased into two thin lines. "A-Yu," he said, "what kind of Wenzhou dialect do you call that?" Laughing, he corrected her: this word had to press down, that one had to curl round and go up. Chen Yu repeated it after him, once, and then again. Grandpa kept shaking his head and kept laughing, as if this were the happiest day he had had since coming to Shanghai.

At last Grandpa patted her hand and said, "That sounded awful. But I un- 32
derstood you." Chen Yu laughed too, and as she laughed, the tears began to fall. When she was little, Grandpa talked and she listened. Now it was her turn to talk, and his turn to listen. That evening, when Chen Yu came in from outside, Grandpa saw her and asked again, "A-Yu, have you eaten?"

32 这一次，陈雨[†]用温州话[‡]回答了他。

† 陈雨 *Chén Yǔ* Chen Yu

‡ 温州话 *Wēnzhōuhuà* Wenzhou dialect

This time Chen Yu answered him in Wenzhou dialect. 32